When Foundations Fall

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When Foundations Fall

by amarisllis

Summary

There's *so much blood.* More than Phanion has ever seen. Enough for at least twenty deaths, and all Phainon can think about it is *what ifs* and *if onlys* and the sight of Mydei dead on the fucking floor.

"Please," he whispers, his voice suddenly fragile and shaky instead of the loud scream from before. "*Please.* You can't die. You can't." It's everything he fears, everything he struggles to keep underneath the surface, every time he and Mydei enter a battle they may never come back from.

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or: a slightly different take on the battle and the aftermath

Notes

AMPHOREUS GAVE US NEW BOYS AND OH BOY THEY WERE INJECTED DIRECTLY INTO MY VEINS I LOVE THEM I LOVE THEM BOTH SO MUCH

See the end of the work for more notes

Phainon sprints through the walls of Castrum Kremnos, barely registering where he's going and blindly following the loud screams of the raging battle ahead. All he can think about is what he heard Mydei say when he left, about how he *deserved* this fight against a mad titan because of who he is. Because of *what* he is. And he knows that Mydei has always had his own convictions, and determination stronger than anyone Phainon has ever met, but…

But he can't help but wonder whether he's using this fight as some bizarre form of self-flagellation, despite it all.

He runs faster, even as his lungs burn and his legs ache. All he can do is wonder how many times Mydei has died already, how many new wounds he will have to bear because Phainon left him here to rot fighting a god that wouldn't die.

He thinks about how much the two of them have shared together, from frosty early meetings, to long, drawn-out sparring sessions full of laughter and exhilaration.

To many long nights thereafter, full of scorching heat and tender kindling and adrenaline rushes like nothing else.

And Phainon left him here to die without saying goodbye.

Echoes of Mydei yelling chase him all through the ruins, as he gets closer and closer to the battlefield. Nikador roars right back, chilling Phainon's blood even through the scorching heat. Until…

Until Mydei's voice suddenly goes quiet, and silence fills the air.

"No , " Phainon chokes out, bursting into the room just as he catches a glimpse of red-orange hair crashing into a pillar on the wall before crumbling into a heap.

Debris scatters the arena. Nikador seems to be recovering from one of Mydei's blows, but Mydei isn't moving, isn't getting back up like he always

does.

“ *Mydei!”* Phainon screams, vaulting over debris and groaning as he pushes a chunk of rock off of Mydei’s… body.

There’s blood all over him. His eyes are vacant, lifeless, and Phainon feels his oxygen being snatched away the longer he looks. He knows that Mydei is going to wake up, but he’s never actually been here as the lights went out, and the longer he stares at his body the more Phainon struggles to breathe.

He’s absolutely *covered* in blood. It soaks his pants, obscures the bright red of his tattoos, and seeps into his hair. Phainon can see a deep gash across his chest, and though the other wounds he’s sustained must have closed already, Phainon can see deep purple bruising all over him.

“Wake up,” Phainon chokes out, his voice wavering. “Wake up. Please.”

Somewhere in the back of his mind, he’s always wondered whether Mydei’s immortality will run out someday.

But a moment later, Mydei takes a deep, ragged breath, body flailing even as he cries out in pain.

Phainon’s chest aches. “Easy. Take it easy.”

It takes a minute for Mydei to notice him, and when he does, he grips Phainon’s wrist tightly as he frowns. “Wh’t’re you… doin’ here…”

Phainon gives him a weak smile. “I’m your backup, remember?”

Mydei scoffs, even as bruised and battered as he is, as he stubbornly tries to sit up. Phainon rests a hand on his chest, slowly pushing him back down. “D’n’t need ya’. What ab’t the city?”

“Taken care of. Just… take a breath. Please. I’m your support until Castorice and our guests arrive with good news.”

Phainon swallows, taking in the blood, the bruising, the dead, empty look in Mydei’s eyes. Even now, he’s still beautiful. “You’re hurt.”

His voice breaks on the words. For all Mydei's prowess as a warrior, for all his own experience on the battlefield, he's never been able to stand seeing Mydei hurt.

"I'm… fine," Mydei says, his voice ragged and faint. "Need to… keep going. Get… out of here."

Phainon frowns, a lump rising in his throat. "No way," he says, his hand pressing more firmly on Mydei's chest to make him stay down. He hasn't healed yet; if he goes charging back into the battlefield now, Phainon will have to watch him die again. "I'm staying with you."

"Don't need it," Mydei says, more firmly this time, and Phainon curses his eternal stubbornness.

Anger surges through Phainon now, surging inside him as he feels tears prick at the corners of his eyes. He's always admired Mydei's strength, his bravery, but gods be *damned* , he wishes it were nowhere to be found right now. "Mydei—Let me help you." His voice is hard now, angry. "I am not leaving you here to die."

"You—"

But Phainon has had enough, emotion surging violently like a rising tide as he leans in close and his voice rises to a scream. "For once in your stupid, idiotic, *self-righteous* life, can you forget about your gods-damned pride and *let me help you! "*

Mydei stares, his eyes wide, orange shining even underneath all the blood. Phanion glares back at him, breathing hard, chest heaving in time with the tears streaming down his face.

Because that's how it's always been, hasn't it? Phainon always reaching out, always trying to ease his pain, and Mydei never letting him, determined to suffer in some perverse attempt not to let Phainon suffer more.

There's *so much blood.* More than Phanion has ever seen. Enough for at least twenty deaths, and all Phainon can think about it is *what ifs* and *if*

onlys and the sight of Mydei dead on the fucking floor.

“Please,” he whispers, his voice suddenly fragile and shaky instead of the loud scream from before. “*Please.* You can’t die. You can’t.” It’s everything he fears, everything he struggles to keep underneath the surface, every time he and Mydei enter a battle they may never come back from.

Slowly, Mydei lifts a blood-stained hand and brushes a tear from Phainon’s face. Phainon breathes a shaky laugh, uncaring of the blood soaking his skin, as Mydei cups his cheek in a palm, continuing to brush away water.

Mydei swallows, taking deep, ragged breaths. Each one soothes something inside Phainon’s chest, putting out the fire that had been raging ever since he left Mydei behind.

“You… idiot,” he says, his voice still weaker than Phainon has ever heard it before. He has seen Mydei withstand countless battles by now, but never like this, never something that has tested the bounds of his indestructible body so close to its breaking point. “Quit… bein’ a baby.”

In spite of everything, it makes Phainon laugh, as he leans forward to press their foreheads together. “Is that a yes?”

Mydei huffs, struggling to sit up. Phainon watches the wounds on his chest start to close, wondering exactly how badly, how deeply he’s been scarred this time, just how long he will spend feeling that pain.

Because even though he’s immortal, he still feels pain. Phainon spends agonizing nights thinking about it, about how much he must hurt, even when they’re in the same bed.

“You’re not immortal,” Mydei chokes out through gritted teeth. But he accepts Phainon’s offered hands nonetheless, leaning against his side as he struggles to get his bearings again. “You make one wrong move, and it’s over.”

Their eyes meet, and underneath the mask, the picture of very *real* strength and resolve and tenacity, Phainon can see something else.

Fear.

Mydei grips the back of Phainon’s head, gripping his hair tightly and pulling him in close. Phainon snakes a hand up the back of his neck, giving as good as he gets.

Underneath it all, Mydei is *scared* . Phainon doesn’t recall *ever* seeing Mydei scared before.

“Don’t you dare die,” Mydei gasps.

Phainon gives him a wobbly smile. “You either. We don’t know how far your ‘immortality’ will stretch.”

Mydei’s lip curls up in a tiny smile, and it makes something in Phainon’s blood *sing* .

He’s okay, he thinks, trying to calm the restlessness coursing through his veins. *You weren’t too late.*

“Are you doubting me?” He sounds stronger already, and even though something inside Phainon still aches at the thought of how much he’s suffered, his smile grows. “Really? Now?”

Unable to resist, he leans up to press a kiss against Mydei’s forehead, even as Nikador roars behind them, preparing for another strike. “Never. You know that.”

Mydei takes another deep breath, giving Phainon a long, lingering look. He looks like he wants to say something, but another loud roar from Nikador snaps him out of the reverie they’ve found themselves in, and instead he scowls, shoving Phainon off of him. “Just… stay alive.”

There it is again. That undercurrent of fear. Of *worry* .

Phainon draws his sword, as Mydei steadies himself on his feet.

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Nikador disappears in a shining shimmer of gold, and the Coreflame floats before them, waiting to be taken home.

Phainon should be feeling triumphant. He should… He should be celebrating. The adrenaline keeps him upright, even as blood drips from multiple cuts.

But even standing before Divinity, all Phainon can think about is Mydei.

Even as he touches the Coreflame, even as warmth surges through him before being extinguished once more, he can only stare at him as death after death after *death* plays in his mind.

But Mydei is standing upright, breathing hard and looking utterly, *utterly* exhausted, but he even manages to smile as Phainon offers him the Coreflame. *He's okay.*

Pain seeps through Phainon's entire body, and dimly he registers that the room is… spinning. Suddenly, everything has gone hazy, and almost as an afterthought, he glances down at his robes. Mydei seems to catch on at the same moment he does, shouting something that Phainon can't hear and rushing forward with wide eyes.

Redness seeps through the blue and white fabric, spreading from a point on his torso and rapidly ballooning outward.

Oh, he thinks, with a nervous laugh. *It seems.… It's worse than I thought.*

Warm, strong arms catch him as he falls, and even before he has time to worry about what happens to the Coreflame, he finds himself calling Mydei's name.

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Phainon comes awake slowly, sore and aching. He doesn't quite remember what happened; they were fighting Nikador, and then afterwards…

Phainon gasps as the pieces come together, suddenly struggling to sit up. But before he can get very far, a warm hand presses firmly against his chest.

“Take it easy, stupid. That Coreflame of yours may have healed you, but do you really want to push it?”

As his vision clears, Phainon takes note of familiar red-orange hair and bright eyes, holding him down against what he realizes is a bed.

“Mydei,” Phainon says, relief flooding his voice. Mydei watches him with a small smile, softer than the usual stoic expression he usually wears in public. “You’re alright.”

Mydei rolls his eyes, shaking his head, but he accepts Phainon’s hand all the same. “Of course I’m alright.”

A lump rises in his throat as he scans Mydei’s bare chest. It looks even worse in the light, bruises so purple they’re almost black.

Mydei catches him looking, and notices the tears in his eyes. He sighs, sitting down on the bed and gently easing Phainon back down. “It looks worse than it is.”

Phainon’s eyes water at that. He’s always doing this, always trying to take on the worst burdens silently, with no one to help him. “It looks pretty bad. Let me—”

“No,” Mydei says firmly, shaking his head. “You need to rest. The Coreflame healed you up, but you’re still recovering.”

“I feel better already.” And it’s not even a lie. Phainon *does* feel better; the longer he sits here, the more he feels the Coreflame taking away the worst of his pain. “I think the flame is taking its time healing me before I give it back to Aglaea.”

Mydei narrows his eyes at him for a moment, before he allows himself to be pushed down onto the bed next to Phainon. Phainon leans over him, gingerly running a hand against a bare patch of his arm. “Have you seen a healer?”

“Nothin’ to heal,” he says, shrugging. “The wounds are closed. It’s just scars and bruises now.”

Phainon’s eyes start to water again, as he painstakingly catalogues every bruise in his memory. Mydei watches him for a long moment, before sighing deeply and reaching up.

“Don’t worry,” he says softly, his hand tangling in Phainon’s hair.

Phainon laughs wetly. “You can barely move without being in pain.” As good at Mydei is at hiding it, Phainon can see the way little movements cost him. “How do you expect me not to worry?”

Mydei’s lip curls as he laughs a little, shaking his head. “I told you,” he whispers. “Quit being a baby.”

“I’m not—”

He doesn’t get to finish the sentence. Mydei swallows down the rest of it, claiming Phainon’s mouth with a kiss somehow gentle and fiery all at once. Phainon lets out a shaky breath, groaning as he leans up to take more, hand weaving into Mydei’s hair. He’s careful not to pull, not to hurt him more than he’s already been hurt, but all he can think about at the moment their lips touch is the possibility that he may have never gotten to have this again.

“Mydei—” Phainon gasps, but Mydei steals his words again, pulling him close and surrounding him with warmth.

“You’re stupid,” Mydei mumbles against his mouth.

“You’re *hurt* .” Phainon leans in to kiss him again. “I couldn’t stay away and do *nothing* .”

Mydei huffs, but he snakes a hand up to cup Phainon’s face even as he shakes his head. “You’re not as indestructible as me.” There’s a slight shakiness to his voice, and it’s more uncertainty than he would ever show anyone else.

Phainon makes a noise that's half moan, half sob. "I'm–"

"And don't you *dare* apologize."

"But—"

"Don't." Mydei pulls back to look at him then, and the fire in his eyes scorches Phainon's soul. "It was my choice. You were needed elsewhere. It wasn't your fault."

Phainon swallows thickly. "How many times did you die?"

"You want me to tell you so you can beat yourself up like an idiot? No chance."

Phainon presses their foreheads together. "I hate that I just… I just left you there. I hate that you suffered."

Mydei pulls back, brushing Phainon's hair away from his face and staring at him for a long, long moment. The touch is soft, achingly so, and yet it sets Phainon's skin ablaze all the same. "You've suffered too," he whispers. "We'll both suffer even more before this war is over."

It's not meant to be a resolution, but Mydei punctuates the statement by leaning over onto the small nightstand and handing Phainon a small bowl of salve.

"If you wanna' play nurse," Mydei says, shrugging. "Go ahead."

Phainon gives him a wobbly smile, sitting up and helping Mydei get comfortable on the bed. Guilt still turns his stomach in knots, festering in the darkest parts of him and waiting for him to come out again, but for now, he could tend to Mydei's wounds and keep him from any more pain.

For now, it would have to keep the ghosts at bay.

End Notes

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